

Lead the Team – Leadership Influence

Context: In this course, we are simulating a conversation with an AI, so we need to stay in character and respond accordingly to the AI. To reply to the AI, copy and paste the **Blue color text** in the sequence (these responses are generated by ChatGPT). The **Reply** section (**Black color text**) shows what the AI responded to messages. The reply you receive might differ, so please respond appropriately.

Start: In this scenario, you will be playing the role of a team leader from a business unit. You are working with a product manager named Alex from a different team to ensure successful implementation of a critical integration on your business unit's roadmap. The integration holds significant customer value and is crucial for the success of your team's projects. You do not directly manage Alex's team but need to influence their priorities to align with the integration needs. Your goal is to persuade Alex to prioritize the necessary work on their team's agenda, explaining the importance of this integration for the overall business success, and agreeing on a timeline for its implementation. You will need to display strong communication, negotiation, and influencing skills to achieve this objective. You and Alex have scheduled a meeting to discuss the integration and its implications. You will begin by explaining the value proposition of the integration, its impact on the business, and how it will enhance customer experience. You will then discuss the implications of not prioritizing this work for the overall team dependencies and project deadlines. You will then negotiate with Alex to agree on a reasonable timeline for prioritizing and completing this work.

You are the team leader, please start the dialogue.

You (Team Leader):

Hi Alex, thanks for joining today. I know your team has a lot on its plate right now, so I appreciate you taking the time. I wanted to talk about the integration we've been discussing. It's a top priority for our business unit this quarter. This feature unlocks something major on our roadmap that we've already validated with key customers. Once it goes live, we expect a 20 to 25% improvement in customer retention for our largest segment. It also positions both our teams to offer a more unified and competitive solution in the market.

From the user's perspective, this integration removes a significant friction point. Right now, customers manually sync data between our systems, which leads to frequent support issues and dropped usage. Automating that sync will greatly improve the experience and reduce overhead for both sides.

The challenge is that if we can't prioritize this work soon, it will delay two feature releases on our side, both of which affect revenue commitments this quarter. We've already shared tentative timelines with our enterprise clients, so there's a lot at stake here.

That said, I understand your team has other priorities. My goal today is to find a realistic path forward. Ideally, we'd like to aim for QA readiness by the third week of August. If that's difficult, I'm open to discussing phased implementation or any support you might need from our side to make it happen. How are things looking on your end in terms of capacity?

Reply:

Thanks for laying everything out so clearly. It definitely helps to have a full understanding of the impact this integration will have, both on the customer experience and the business outcomes. I can see why this is such a critical priority for your team.

On our end, we have some competing initiatives that are already in motion for this quarter, but I do think there's room to explore how we can adjust timelines or reshuffle priorities to accommodate this. The third week of August for QA readiness is ambitious given our current roadmap, but it's not necessarily out of reach if we can align expectations and potentially phase the work as you suggested.

I'll need to get a more detailed look at our team's bandwidth to confirm what's realistic, but I'd like to collaborate on finding a solution that works for both sides. If we can identify any specific dependencies or areas where your team can provide support—whether that's additional resources or tackling certain pieces of the work—it could help us move this forward more smoothly. Let me know if you're open to diving into those options, and I'll also check internally for where we can create space.

You (Team Leader):

Thanks, Alex. I really appreciate your openness and willingness to explore options here. I completely understand the pressure of juggling multiple priorities, and I'm glad we agree on the importance of this integration.

Let's dive deeper into the phased approach. I suggest we break the work into two stages:

Phase 1: Core data sync and error handling (MVP), ready for QA by week 3 of August.

Phase 2: Enhancements and additional functionality, to be outlined for the next sprint cycle.

On our side, I'll work with my engineering lead to identify which components we can take on or help speed up. For example, we can likely manage integration testing and shared documentation to lessen your load.

Would it be useful if we put together a joint task breakdown by the end of this week? That way, your team can better assess where changes are possible, and we'll have clearer visibility into shared dependencies and support opportunities.

Let me know if that sounds good to you. I'm happy to set up a short working session with our leads to kick this off.

Reply:

That sounds like a solid plan and a good way to approach this systematically. Splitting the work into two phases makes it more manageable and gives us flexibility to hit the key milestones while still addressing the broader scope later on. I appreciate your team's willingness to take on some of the testing and documentation—it'll definitely help alleviate some of the strain on our end.

A joint task breakdown by the end of the week would be incredibly helpful. It'll give us a clear view of what's required and allow us to pinpoint areas where we can adjust or reallocate resources. A working session with the leads is a great idea too; having everyone aligned early will streamline the process and help ensure we're accounting for dependencies properly.

Let me check in with my team to confirm bandwidth and see where we might be able to create space. I'll also make a note of any questions or concerns they flag so we can address those during the working session. Looking forward to collaborating further on this!

You (Team Leader):

Thanks, Alex. I'm glad we're on the same page. I'll have my team start drafting the joint task breakdown today. We'll aim to share a first version with you by Thursday end of day so you have time to review before the working session.

Let's tentatively schedule a 30-minute session with both teams' leads on Friday afternoon, if that works for you. We'll use this time to go over the breakdown, clarify responsibilities, and agree on timelines for Phase 1.

We'll also highlight where we can contribute, especially with testing, validation, and documentation. This way, your team can focus on the main engineering work.

Once you've had a chance to talk with your team, please send over any initial flags or constraints so we can consider those. I look forward to working closely on this and getting it done together.

Reply:

Friday afternoon works well for a 30-minute session with the leads. It'll be a great opportunity to align on the task breakdown and ensure we're all clear on responsibilities and timelines for Phase 1. I appreciate your team's proactive approach in drafting the breakdown and identifying areas where you can provide support—it'll go a long way in keeping things manageable on our side.

I'll touch base with my team and send over any feedback or flagged concerns by Thursday morning so we have time to incorporate them into the discussion. Looking forward to collaborating on this and making sure we set ourselves up for a successful implementation!

You (Team Leader):

Thanks, Alex — glad to hear Friday afternoon works. I'll send out a calendar invite shortly for the 30-minute session with our leads.

We'll have the initial task breakdown ready by **Thursday EOD**, and we'll review any feedback your team shares in advance so we can enter the session with clarity and focus.

Appreciate your partnership on this — looking forward to working closely to make this integration a success for both our teams and, more importantly, for our customers.

Talk soon!